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Preston Thorpe is a software engineer at a San Francisco

startup — he's also serving his 11th year in prison



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It's true: Thorpe is serving his 11th year in prison for drug-related crimes. Still, he has **worked full-time** from his cell at a venture-funded, San Francisco-based startup since May.

IMAGE CREDITS: ANASTASIA VUJIC / GETTY IMAGES

"I reached out to him in January, just to understand and get to know him," Costa said. "Since then, I've had deep conversations with him about his change of heart that led him to be in the position where he is today ... Knowing his story increased our respect for him personally."

Thorpe is part of an experimental program in the Maine state prison system that allows incarcerated people to work remote jobs from custody. Though unconventional, these opportunities have proven immensely rehabilitative.

Kicked out of his home as a teenager, Thorpe resorted to selling drugs that he bought from the dark web and ended up in prison by the time he was 20. He got out a few years later, but with no money to his name and nowhere safe to live, he was arrested again 14 months later.

“I was a complete idiot,” Thorpe told TechCrunch over a video call from



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“When I came to Maine, it was completely different,” he reminisced. “COVID happened right after I came up here, and it just gave me a chance — there was no one around that I felt like I had to act or prove myself to. It was just me. I actually felt like maybe it’s not over; maybe I could actually end up having a normal life. I had this kind of epiphany: ‘I’m going to make something of myself.’”

At the Mountain View prison, Thorpe enrolled remotely at the University of Maine at Augusta. Around the same time, Colby College wanted to hire one of

its incarcerated graduate students to be an adjunct professor. It was an unconventional proposal, but the Maine Department of Corrections commissioner, Randall Liberty, felt like taking a risk.

“After consideration, I allowed that to happen, and over time, it’s been very successful,” Commissioner Liberty told TechCrunch. “His students are able to come visit him at the prison, and he can tour them around. It provides for a real diversity of opinions, thoughts, and backgrounds. It makes for a rich environment to learn.”



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surrender 10% of their pay to the state, plus any other payments that may be required for restitution, legal fees, or child support.

“Maine has been a real groundbreaker in this area,” Haley Shoaf, co-executive director of [Unlocked Labs](#), told TechCrunch. Unlocked Labs, where Thorpe worked prior to Turso, hires incarcerated and formerly incarcerated engineers to make educational software for use in prisons.

“[Maine] put all this infrastructure in place during COVID to allow for remote education, and then once that infrastructure was in place, all of a sudden, it expanded the amount of opportunities people could take advantage of,” Shoaf said.

Rehabilitation done right

Commissioner Liberty has worked in law enforcement for 43 years, but it was only after he served in Iraq that his approach to rehabilitation began to shift.



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“It’s very short-sighted, ridiculous to lock them up and release them more traumatized than when they arrived, right?” he said. “Many states have 60% return to custody rates. In Maine, we hover between 21% to 23% for males; women return at a rate of 9%. And if you attend college classes in Maine, you come back at a rate of 0.05% — you don’t come back at all.”

Commissioner Liberty has also found that under his purview, Maine prisons have become less violent. Last year, a maximum-security prison in Maine

saw only seven assaults on prison staff, a dramatic improvement from 87 assaults in 2017.

“When you treat people like people, they become the best version of themselves,” Shoaf said.

Thorpe himself is evidence that Commissioner Liberty’s toils are proving successful. The software engineer takes full responsibility for his criminal history, but he feels like a changed man.



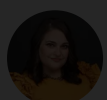
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Amanda Silberling

Senior Writer | [X](#) [t](#) [in](#)

Amanda Silberling is a senior writer at TechCrunch covering the intersection of technology and culture. She has also written for publications like Polygon, MTV, the Kenyon Review, NPR, and Business Insider. Sh...

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Prison spending is 5x more than higher education, and ~10 percent of the U.S. prison population is in California.

Part of the reason why people return to prison after they are released is because they have no access to education while they're incarcerated.

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On today's Breaking Into Startups episode, we talk about an educational program that is paving the road to success, called [The Last Mile](#).

One year after their release, more than 75 percent of California's formerly incarcerated can't find jobs. One former prisoner, Kenyatta Leal, was serving a life sentence in San Quentin prison and was determined to change that number.

On this prison, Last Mile

Leal also skills he Leal, the express internet breaking

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If you want to learn more about criminal justice reform, feel free to reach out to ruben@breakingintostartups.com and we can connect you with the right people.



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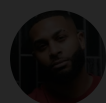
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Twilio has invested \$250,000 in startup Edovo, which creates tablet-based educational content for incarcerated individuals. Twilio has also invested grant money in the International Rescue Committee, MindRight and Caravan Studios. Last year, Twilio awarded over \$1.5 million in impact funds and plans to award an additional \$1.5 million by the end of this year.

Edovo works with facilities to bring in secure wireless networks and tablets that access Edovo's educational platform. The incentive-based learning program covers a variety of areas, including literacy, college course work, cognitive behavioral therapy and vocational training.

Upon completion of certain lessons, incarcerated individuals can receive certificates and entertainment options. They can also use Edovo to stay in touch with family.

Right now, most facilities have access to the program.

"This is a challenge for us as a co-founder to impact the figure of our challenge."

On average, educational programs of returnees participating in the U.S. program.

"Our goal has been to free people," said.



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Tech and VC heavyweights join the Disrupt 2025 agenda

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A prison video visitation service could protect private calls



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Fearing the spread of coronavirus, jails and prisons remain on lockdown. Visitors are unable to see their loved ones serving time, forcing friends and families to use prohibitively expensive video visitation services that often don't work.

But now the security and privacy of these systems are under scrutiny after one St Louis-based prison video visitation provider had a security lapse that

exposed thousands of phone calls between inmates and their families, but also calls with their attorneys that were supposed to be protected by attorney-client privilege.

HomeWAV, which serves a dozen prisons across the U.S., left a dashboard for one of its databases exposed to the internet without a password, allowing anyone to read, browse and search the call logs and transcriptions of calls between inmates and their friends and family members. The transcriptions also showed the phone number of the caller, which inmate, and the duration of the call.



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Somil Trivedi, a senior staff attorney at the ACLU's Criminal Law Reform Project, told TechCrunch: "What we see again and again is that the rights of incarcerated people are the first to be trampled when the system fails — as it always, invariably does."



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HOMEWAV, A PRISON VIDEO VISITATION TECH COMPANY, EXPOSED THOUSANDS OF PHONE CALLS BETWEEN INMATES AND THEIR FAMILIES, BUT ALSO CALLS WITH THEIR ATTORNEYS THAT WERE SUPPOSED TO BE PROTECTED BY ATTORNEY-CLIENT PRIVILEGE. (IMAGE: HOMEWAV/YOUTUBE)

The calls between inmates and their attorneys, however, are not supposed to be monitored because of attorney-client privilege, a rule that protects the

communications between an attorney and their client from being used in court.

Despite this, there are known cases of U.S. prosecutors using recorded calls between an attorney and their incarcerated clients. Last year, prosecutors in Louisville, Ky., allegedly listened to dozens of calls between a murder suspect and his attorneys. And, earlier this year defense attorneys in Maine said they were routinely recorded by several county jails, and their calls protected under attorney-client privilege were turned over to prosecutors in at least four cases.



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TechCrunch spoke to two attorneys, whose communications with their clients in prison over the past six months were recorded and transcribed by HomeWAV, but asked that we not name them or their clients as doing so might harm their client's legal defense. Both expressed alarm that their calls had been recorded. One of the attorneys said that they had verbally asserted attorney-client privilege on the call, while the other attorney also considered that their call was protected by attorney-client privilege but declined to comment further until they had spoken to their client.

Another defense attorney, Daniel Repka, told TechCrunch confirmed one of his calls with a client in prison in September was recorded, transcribed and subsequently exposed, but said that the call was not sensitive.

“We did not relay any information that would be considered protected by attorney-client privilege,” said Repka. “Anytime I have a client who calls me from a jail, I’m very conscious and aware of the possibility not only of security breaches, but also the potential ability to access these phone calls by the county attorney’s office,” he said.



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Even prior to the pandemic, some prisons ended in-person visitation in favor of video calls.

Video visitation technology is now a billion-dollar industry, with companies like Securus making millions each year by charging callers often exorbitant fees to call their incarcerated loved ones.

HomeWAV isn't the only video visitation service to have faced security issues.

In 2015, an apparent breach at Securus resulted in the leak of some 70 million inmate phone calls by an anonymous hacker and [shared with The Intercept](#). Many of the recordings in the cache also contained calls designated protected by attorney-client privilege, the publication reported.

In August, Diachenko reported a [similar security lapse](#) at TelMate, another prison visitation provide, which saw millions of inmate messages exposed



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